to the mazhar saying ‘what would the King of the West, as the Sultan of Rum, say if he heard all this?’ Akbar reacted sharply, accusing the men of secretly being spies from Constantinople, and sarcastically suggesting they go back to that country. The debate took a rather heated turn when Birbal joined in and Shahbaz Khan rounded on him, calling him a ‘cursed infidel’ and threatened him—Akbar could no longer contain himself and shouted to the dissenters in surprisingly robust language saying ‘would that they would beat your mouths with a slipper full of filth!’

Sensing these undercurrents of hostility and bitterness, Akbar decided to make a pilgrimage to Ajmer, as he had done so many times in the past decade in gratitude, hope, and prayer, but this time ‘as a means of calming the public and enhancing the submission of the recalcitrant’, according to Abu’l Fazl. Akbar dismounted several miles from the sacred spot to continue the journey on foot but ‘sensible people smiled’, wrote Badauni, and said ‘it was strange that His Majesty should have such a faith in the Khwaja of Ajmer, while he rejected the foundation of everything our Prophet, from whose “skirt” hundreds of thousands of saints of the highest degree like the Khwajah had sprung’. Perhaps Akbar might have sensed in the elements themselves a warning. On his way back from Ajmer, torrential rains lasting for three days caused a sudden, catastrophic flood which ‘washed out a large number of men, cattle and goods’.

This was to be Akbar’s last visit to Ajmer, this mystical spot where he had brought the turbulence of his thoughts so many times over the past ten years. These many repeated visits to the dargah, especially in the past decade, had been crucial in guiding his trajectory, as Akbar began to look for alternatives to orthodox Islam. Akbar would have been exposed to pantheistic Sufi doctrines, including fana, or extinction of the ego or the self, where the need to overcome one’s own bodily desires transcended other religious considerations. The Sufis had pragmatically accommodated themselves to the presence of other beliefs and often incorporated aspects of Hindu and Buddhist practices. ‘They shunned ritual and ceremony,’ according to historian Muzaffar Alam, ‘and spoke the language of the common people.’ Akbar had also carefully cultivated the symbology of the Ajmer dargah, along with Shaikh Salim’s living blessings, and effortlessly made it a part of the legacy of the Mughals of Hindustan. Now, finally, Akbar may have felt he had outgrown the need for this constant, visible